

Peaks, Mines, and Graves In Angeles National Forest

After a long few weekends spent doing smaller hikes, trail maintenance, and the general less-than-strenuous fun that surrounds the holidays it was a new year and time to get back to the real fun stuff!

With the arrival of (California) winter certain peaks now have enough snow where they are basically off limits to people without a death wish or special training and equipment. That means either looking either to out to the desert peaks or down to some of the lower ones. The latter is how we ended up out in Angeles National Forest.

The route was a loop out in Angeles National Forest that included 4 HPS peaks: Rabbit, Granite, Roundtop, and Iron. There was an official hike there a few weeks later that did not mention special equipment requirements so I bet on it being passable. Also the 10 mile, 4,000 ft of climbing it sounded like a good solid day hike for Kim and I.

Had we gone with the official HPS group the hike would have likely started out with a leisurely hike up a well groomed dirt fire road and then pick up a ridgeline use trail to the first peak. That would of course have lacked a certain flavor of adventure I like to provide on all of my hikes.

So, instead we grabbed our gear and I lead us up what could possibly be considered a rather steep climb through soft dirt, crumbling rocks, and sometimes dense desert vegetation. Here we see Kim with her head down and so her expression of absolute job at my route is not visible:



The intelligence of this route came into question as we reached the 2/3 mark and I was practically on my hands and knees doing everything I can not to slide down the hillside on top of Kim. The dirt was as soft as ash in most places and each step up slide back down about half way. Plants and rocks had a bad habit of coming apart in your hand the second you tried to hold on to them.

Of course that's no reason to do something silly like turn around, we were over half way up the hill after all.

I was up ahead blazing a trail when Kim grabbed the wrong rock and receives a horrendous permanently disfiguring injury. Please zoom in on her finger in the below picture to be horrified. (Not that finger)



Kim displays both her horrendous injury and her opinion of my navigation.



At long last we reach a ridge and the road/trail I'd been aiming for on my topo turns out to be an old overgrown fire road. By this time we've been hiking for about an hour and a half and come a whopping .2 miles. And we still hadn't connected with our planned 10 mile route yet.

With only a small amount of backtracking and "scenic navigation" we find our use trail begin our hike in earnest only a bit battered, bloodied, and scraped.

The first peak, Rabbit, was a small bump that we reached without too much difficulty. The day was turning out quite nice weather wise but as Kim pointed out I had once again taken us out on a route with no signs of other hikers.

Rabbit Peak, first of four!





The peak behind me is the second peak (Granite) as seen from the first (Rabbit.) It was a good climb but never grew steep enough to give us anywhere near the trouble we had during our initial off trail ascent.

Having attained Granite Peak we find out a few interesting details. First off the location of the peak itself seems to be up to interpretation as I had two different GPS waypoints for it neither of which correspond with what I would call the peak.

At the logical location of the peak we did find the red forest service coffee can that would normally contain a peak log but it was empty. We created a temporary replacement out of a baggie and one of my business cards while we ate lunch.



From there we actually drop down quite a bit before doing a small climb up to the third peak called Roundtop. Unimaginative name for a very boring peak. The summit is basically a dirt parking area for the forest road running along this section of the ridge.
yawn



Our goal was to do all 4 peaks but at this point we're only looking at a few more hours of daylight. The last peak can be seen off to the left of the picture below. The route back to the car is off to the right about half way along the ridge but from our earlier experiences we knew the road on our map may not actually be a road anymore



We set out and when we reach the junction which theoretically will lead back to the car we decide to push on for Iron Peak; if we're out after dark (again) we'll just deal with it. That's why we carry flashlights after all.

The climb to Iron was fairly steep but passes quickly.

Peak #4!



We make it to the peak though the sun is now noticeably heading down. Time to head for the car.

While we were climbing up Iron Peak I had noticed a white truck on one of the roads below us. It had stopped on the road as close to our location as it could and sat facing us for at least 10 minutes. I kept an eye on it as we climbed until it eventually drove back further along the road towards Roundtop.

Making it down from the ridge trail to the road we used another patented Matt shortcut which basically consisted of throwing ourselves through heavy brush when we weren't desperately holding on to said branches to prevent an uncontrolled plunge down the slope until we literally dropped onto a road below.

Once again the map is showing roads that don't appear to exist any longer. After some poking around I found the remains of the road on my map, now overgrown and partially collapsed down the hillside in places, and we head down that.

That was when we had our best discovery of the day. A mine!



I ran over to the entrance and to my excitement I find that the entrance is gated but that the gate itself, a red painted metal gate with slats to allow bats to fly in and out, is open!





Inside there are power wires running further back but they look to have fallen into disrepair.

Sadly the imperatives of getting down before dark and not getting killed out where no one would find us stood in the way of any further mine exploration. I'm determined to head back another weekend though so stay tuned for the missing persons report.

We went in one at a time and when I popped out to talk to Kim the white truck made a sudden reappearance as it drove past on the road almost directly on top of us. We both scrambled away from the mine entrance but the truck was already around another corner apparently having missed us. From doing my trip research I knew there was a gold mine in the area called the Monte Cristo mine and I had read that there was a full time overseer on site. I didn't think we were in the right area for the mine but I really didn't want to be confronted by the overseer and see the gate relocked.



We did find several more entrances to the mine but these had gates which appeared to be shut.

We regained the road down below and continued down, keeping an eye out behind us for the reappearance of the white truck which we believed was still behind us at this point.

As we went continued along I caught sight of something down in a gully to the side of the road. It was barely visible from the road itself and I probably would have missed it if the sun hadn't been in just the right position to reflect off something.

Upon closer examination it turned out to be a grave/memorial complete with freshly left flowers and a Budweiser can.



This led to more jokes about the white truck and my commenting how much the person must have been disliked prior to his death to have someone put that Budweiser piss water on his grave.



In the end we made it back to my truck with plenty of time to spare having had good weather and achieved all goals without any major mishaps and only one maiming.

Upon getting home I started looking into the mine we found and determined that we were not in the area of the Monte Cristo mine. What we had found was actually called the Black Cargo mine which has an interesting history. Apparently it used to be privately owned but the forest service seized it from the owner after a long court case where they proved the minerals present inside the mine could never make it commercially viable. So we were not trespassing on private property. I even found a hand drawn map made by a local mine exploration group. It certainly calls for another trip.